divisions of Eastern Europe have followed quite distinct paths. No wonder that, in the Middle Ages, no one thought of the Czechs or Slovenians as Eastern Europeans.

If any evaluation of this kind is possible, one could say that the nations in the Middle Ages which chose the Eastern rite and Byzantine influence did not, in any way, make a bad decision.[10] Quite the contrary: first, the choice was not a voluntary one but was a result of geographical proximity and/or *realpolitik*. Second, and more importantly, until about the eleventh century, Byzantium surpassed the Western European kingdoms and empires in almost every respect: culturally, economically and militarily. In fact, one of the reasons why Diocletian moved the centre of gravity of the empire to the East was that this part was much more civilised and prosperous.[11] People of Byzantium looked down on the then recently converted barbarians in the west. For political leaders of 'Eastern Europe' in the Middle Ages, attachment to Byzantium rather than the West might well have looked more attractive for some very good reasons.

It is also interesting to note another factor: while the countries of today's Eastern Europe were certainly not at the core of Europe in the Middle Ages, they were by no means far from it. Economically speaking, historians talk about the axis of medieval Europe, drawn roughly from Antwerp (or later London) to Florence. For a very long time, this was the area of the most intense economic activity, enabled by fertile valleys, navigable rivers, access to the sea, dense population, and large cities. Looking at the map, one can see that the Czech lands, Slovenia, Slovakia, Hungary and Poland did not really lie far from these centres of medieval Europe and were certainly not further from it than Spain, Portugal or Ireland. In fact, until about AD 1000, economic activity was pretty basic all over Europe. Distinguished British economist Angus Maddison, known for his calculations of historic economic performance, has estimated the GDP of Europe in those days as 400 dollars per capita,[12] both in the East and the West. The European economy only really took off after the year 1000 and it is about that time that Western and Eastern Europe slowly began to diverge economically. For the year 1500, the same author has made the following estimates for GDP per capita (expressed in the same 1990 international dollars and for the territories of present-day countries): Austria 707, Finland 453, France 727, Germany 688, Italy 1,100, the Netherlands 761, Norway